investigations that followed the bomb blast, which then revealed that members of the Hindustan Socialist Republican Army (HSRA) had also been behind the 17 December 1928 assassination of a British official, J.P. Saunders. Sadly, for Saunders, he was mistaken for his boss, J.A. Scott, the superintendent of police who had been in charge when the nationalist figure, Lala Lajpat Rai, was assaulted in October 1928 by police batons. However, although the 1929 manifesto of the HSRA had proclaimed that 'Revolution is Law, Revolution is Order and Revolution is the Truth' in consequence of which 'the youths of our nation have realised this truth', what was meant by 'revolution' was not that it was a single event but an immutable, imperishable and perpetual quest for rebirth, recovery, and regeneration of the present. This meant that it need not be violent. Saunders' assassination was not violence as a political philosophy. This is why it was universally applauded in India. Bhagat Singh's immense popularity immediately thereafter showed him to have vindicated the honour of the Indian people. He alone took the step that he did with Sukhdev and Rajguru. No one else in the Congress Party did.

The Lahore Conspiracy case that followed became one of the most controversial trials of British India. Twenty-four members of the HSRA were initially charged with conspiracy against the government. When Bhagat Singh was moved from the Delhi prison to Mianwali Jail, he objected to the inequalities of treatment between European inmates and Indian inmates. He demanded parity in standards of food, clothing and toiletries. He also demanded to be treated as a political prisoner, with books and a daily newspaper being made available to him and others. He and his fellow prisoners also objected to manual labour and other undignified work. These demands were set out in a 24 June 1929 letter to the Home Member. In protest for these demands a hunger strike followed. After sixty-three days, one of their number, Jatindra Nath Das, died on 13 September 1929. The hunger strikers became household names. Uproar engulfed the country. Bhagat Singh went 116 days without food, surpassing a previous record held by the Irish hunger strikers. It took a heavy toll on him as his weight